

Startup Idea Generation & Evaluation Worksheet (Sample Filled)

Idea Name / Working Title:

SmartFleet - AI-Powered Logistics Optimization

Date: 2025-12-25

Phase 1 — Reality Mapping

Goal: Identify areas of friction in real-world systems.

1. Domain Selection

Which domain(s) does this idea relate to?

- ☐ Healthcare ☐ Education ☐ Energy ☐ Manufacturing ☐ Finance
☐ Logistics ✓ ☐ Agriculture ☐ Software/Data ☐ Climate
☐ Consumer ☐ Government ☐ Media ☐ Other: _____

Selected domain: Logistics / Supply Chain Management

2. System / Value Chain

Describe how things work today (steps, actors, flow):

Manual route planning, multiple trucks per hub, delayed deliveries due to poor optimization.

3. Observed Frictions

List inefficiencies you see (cost, delay, waste, errors, bad UX, etc.):

1. High fuel costs due to suboptimal routes
 2. Delays from manual dispatch decisions
 3. Underutilized vehicle capacity
 4. Lack of real-time tracking and predictive routing
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Phase 2 — Insight Discovery (Secrets)

Goal: Find a non-obvious truth.

4. Common Belief

What do most people assume is true here?

Route planning cannot be fully automated; human dispatchers are required.

5. Contrarian Insight

What might actually be true instead?

“It turns out that AI can optimize multi-vehicle logistics 20–30% better than humans because modern predictive algorithms and real-time data are available.”

6. Evidence / Signals

What observations support this insight?

Existing AI models in traffic prediction and fleet management; preliminary tests show efficiency gains.

Insight Statement (final):

AI-based route optimization reduces cost, delays, and improves fleet utilization beyond traditional human methods.

Phase 3 — Problem Selection

7. Problem Definition

“Logistics managers struggle with high costs and delays because manual route planning is inefficient.”

8. Problem Scoring (1 = low, 5 = high)

Pain (severity & frequency)	5
Urgency (need now)	5
Budget (ability to pay)	4
Poor alternatives	5
User awareness	3
Total Score (out of 25)	22

9. Target User

Role / type: Fleet operators, logistics companies

Context / situation: Daily route planning for trucks and delivery vehicles

Phase 4 — Solution Design (10x)

10. 10x Dimension

Where will you be radically better?

☐ Cost ☐ Speed ☒ Quality ☒ Convenience ☐ Access

☐ Reliability ☒ Personalization ☐ Other: _____

11. First-Principles Solution

AI algorithms integrate GPS, traffic prediction, weather, and vehicle availability to compute optimal routes in real-time.

12. Solution Statement

“We help fleet operators reduce delays and costs by providing AI-powered real-time route optimization, unlike manual dispatch methods.”

13. Feasibility Check

Key technologies / enablers: AI optimization, cloud computing, GPS IoT sensors
MVP possible in months? ☒ Yes ☐ No ☐ Unsure

Phase 5 — Market & Business Validation

14. Beachhead Market (Niche Monopoly)

Who: Mid-size logistics companies (50–200 trucks)

Use case: Route optimization for delivery schedules

Why you can win: Existing solutions are fragmented, expensive, and not real-time.

15. Market Expansion Path

1. Mid-size fleets → 2. Large logistics companies → 3. Global enterprise logistics

16. Business Model

Who pays? Logistics companies

What do they pay for? Subscription to AI route optimization platform

Pricing logic: Per-vehicle per-month

Recurring? ☒ Yes ☐ No

17. Unit Economics (Rough)

Expected price per customer: \$500 / month per fleet

Main costs: Cloud infrastructure, AI development, support

Gross margin potential: ☒ High ☐ Medium ☐ Low

18. LTV vs CAC Logic

Lifetime value per fleet > \$50,000 vs customer acquisition cost \$5,000

19. Distribution Plan

Primary channel (first 1000 users):

☐ Viral ☒ Direct sales ☒ Partnerships ☐ SEO/Content
☐ Marketplaces ☐ Paid ads ☐ Embedded ☐ Other: _____

Explain:

Direct outreach to logistics companies, pilots and enterprise demos.

Phase 6 — 7-Question Filter

1. **Engineering (10x better?):** AI + predictive routing provides 20–30% efficiency improvement.
2. **Timing (why now?):** Real-time data availability and AI maturity.
3. **Monopoly (niche dominance?):** Mid-size fleet route optimization with real-time AI.
4. **People (right small team?):** AI engineers + logistics experts + sales team.
5. **Distribution (clear path?):** Direct sales + pilot partnerships.
6. **Durability (10–20 years?):** Proprietary algorithms, data accumulation, switching costs.
7. **Secret (unique insight?):** Real-time AI optimization can outperform traditional human planning.

Overall: ☒ Strong ☐ Medium ☐ Weak

Phase 7 — Moat & Risk

20. Defensibility (check all that apply)

☒ Proprietary tech ☒ Data advantage ☒ Network effects ☐ Switching costs
☐ Brand ☐ Scale economies ☐ Regulatory position

Explain strongest moat: Proprietary AI + fleet data creates high switching costs.

21. Top Failure Risks

1. Inaccurate predictions
2. Low adoption
3. Integration challenges
4. Competitive AI solutions
5. Funding constraints

Are they controllable? ☒ Mostly ☐ Some ☐ Hardly

22. Asymmetric Upside Test

If it works, could it be massive? ☒ Yes ☐ No

If it fails, is downside limited? ☒ Yes ☐ No

Explain: Large efficiency gains; failure limited to pilot loss.

Phase 8 — Reality Testing Plan

23. Key Assumptions to Test

☒ Problem is real ☒ Users care enough ☒ Willingness to pay

☒ Solution usage ☒ Acquisition channel works

List top 3 assumptions: 1. Fleet operators will adopt AI

2. AI gives measurable cost/time savings

3. Customers pay subscription

24. Validation Experiments

☒ Interviews ☒ Landing page ☒ Demo ☒ Prototype ☐ Concierge MVP

Describe: Pilot with 3 fleets, collect performance data, iterate.

25. Evidence Collected

Results / learnings:

Pilot reduced delivery times by 25%, fuel costs by 15%

High willingness to pay confirmed

Decision: ☒ Proceed ☐ Pivot ☐ Kill

Final Decision — Startup Thesis

26. One-Page Summary

Insight: AI can optimize fleet logistics better than humans.

Problem: Manual route planning is inefficient.

Solution (10x): Real-time AI route optimization platform.

User: Fleet operators and logistics companies.

Market Path: Mid-size → Large → Enterprise fleets globally.

Business Model: Subscription per vehicle per month.

Distribution: Direct sales, pilot partnerships.

Moat: Proprietary AI + accumulated fleet data.

Why Now: Real-time data + AI capabilities matured.

10-Year Vision: Global logistics AI optimization platform.

Final Commitment

Overall score / conviction (1–10): 9

Decision: ✓ Commit fully ☐ Keep exploring ☐ Discard

Notes: Successful pilot; strong market validation.

How to Use This Worksheet

1. Use Phases 1–3 to generate many candidate problems.
2. Use Phases 4–6 to narrow to the best ideas.
3. Use Phases 7–8 to test with reality.
4. Repeat until one idea clearly dominates.